destroying them as he feared being raided by the police. In the words of Chaman Lal, ‘The loss of these invaluable documents must surely rank as one of the great tragedies of the period.’ That a bundle of documents existed appears to be the considered view of Chaman Lal for as he explains,

> Bhagat Singh’s father was keen to acquire the papers, or at least to see them. Lajjawati refused to give them to him, purportedly on Bhagat Singh’s own instructions. We must consider ourselves fortunate that some member of his family, probably Kulbir Singh, managed to retrieve Jail Notebook . . .[11]

This throws up a couple of questions. First, if the bundle of documents, smuggled out of prison by Kumari Lajjawati was eventually destroyed by an unnamed friend of Bejoy Kumar Sinha, with only ‘Why I Am an Atheist’ and ‘Letter to Young Political Workers’ being published, how can we know for sure that four named book manuscripts also specifically existed? Second, the fact that the two named articles were indeed published from this smuggled bundle of documents by Lala Feroz Chand does suggest that something was in all probability written during his two years in jail, although it is unlikely that he would have had the time to complete four books in their entirety. This much is fairly recognized by Chaman Lal, noting of Bhagat Singh how ‘during this time, he was engaged in agitation inside the jail, as well preparing for the trial’. This being so, ‘it seems unlikely that he could actually have finished writing four full-fledged books, even considering his enormous energy and willpower’.[12] Nevertheless, the belief that a treasure trove of lost Bhagat Singh documents existed refuses to die. This is perhaps best encapsulated in the journalist Bhupendra Hooja’s lament that ‘the vacuum of these precious manuscripts’ is something which ‘no amount of literature on or about Bhagat Singh . . . can fill’.[13] The result is, as Moffat points out, that at the very least the existence of ‘a fragmented assemblage of personal notes’ is something which today ‘fuels a narrative of unconsecrated potential, opening space for rumination’.[14] Yet, if it were possible so to do, what would a consecrated potential look like? This is the perpetual question to which an answer must be sought.